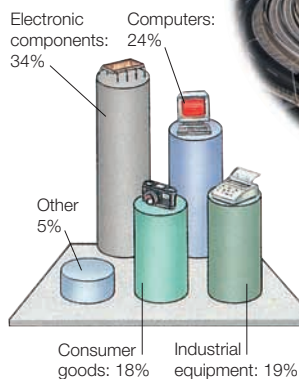




JAPAN

Capital city: Tokyo
Area: 145,882 sq miles (377,835 sq km)
Population: 128,000,000
Official language: Japanese
Major religions: Shinto and Buddhist 92%, other 8%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Yen
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 82 years
People per doctor: 496
Televisions: 707 per 1,000 people

Electronic goods produced in Japan



The Japanese excel at making electronic goods, such as televisions, cameras, digital watches, and computers, that are sold worldwide. Many Japanese companies are world leaders in the research and development of new technology.

JAPAN

FOR MANY CENTURIES, Japan was closed to foreigners and wary of the outside world. Today, it is a leading industrial and technological power and one of the world's richest countries. This transformation is even more remarkable given Japan's mountainous landscape and lack of natural resources. Most raw materials have to be imported from abroad. Japanese people enjoy a high standard of living, with good health care and education systems. Average life expectancy in Japan is among the highest in the world. Western influence is strong, but people remain proud of their culture and traditions.



The Rainbow Bridge connects the port with the city.

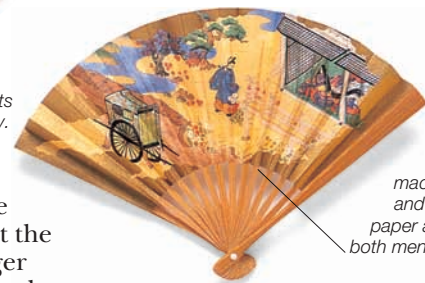
ECONOMIC STRENGTH

Japan has a highly developed infrastructure and industrial base. One of the main reasons why the country's industries have grown so quickly is that the Japanese are very hardworking. Many of the larger companies are like families, providing housing and health care for their employees. However, society is slowly changing. Young people are starting to question this working culture, especially as the economy began to slow down in the 1990s and unemployment rose.



MAKING MONEY

Japan is a huge economic power. It invests in land and property around the world, and many of the world's largest commercial banks are Japanese. Japan's economic and industrial heart is the capital, Tokyo. The world's second largest stock exchange and the headquarters of many banks and corporations can be found in Tokyo's Central Business District. It is said that if an earthquake hit this area, the world would suffer economic chaos.



Traditional folding fans made of bamboo and covered with paper are carried by both men and women.

TRADITIONAL DRESS

People in Japan wear kimonos for religious festivals and other special occasions. A kimono (which means "clothing") is a long-sleeved, wrap-around robe, tied with a broad sash. It may be made of silk, cotton, or wool. Many formal silk kimonos are richly colored and beautifully embroidered.

Black silk kimono



Wooden clogs, or geta



CHERRY BLOSSOM

Japanese people share a love of nature and pay close attention to the changing seasons. The blossoming of cherry trees is a reminder that spring has arrived. The first blossoms appear in southern Kyushu. Their progress is plotted on maps shown on television news. The blossoms last for a few days, and people celebrate by picnicking under the cherry trees.